meat. The men are served meat every Sunday because they work outside the camp." She bowed her head. "Simone was twenty-two." The woman wiped a tear from her face. "It wasn't illness that killed her." Raising her shoulders and lifting her head, she seemed to arrive at a realization. "They'll kill us all."

Léa felt sick. Revulsion mingled with guilt as she instinctively stepped back, trying to separate herself from the grieving woman and the reality before her. Had Simone paid the price for not taking the gendarme up on his offer? Léa struggled with the thought of taking the poor woman's bed. It felt deeply wrong. Maître Mallon had said that war hardens people. Léa wondered if she needed to do the same, forcing herself to focus on what she needed tonight, not on who had slept in the bed before.

"Léa?" She turned to see Edith approaching, calling her name.

"Yes?"

"You're wanted at the gate."

She had a sinking feeling. "Tell the gendarme I won't go."

"But—"

"I went this morning, like you said and was assigned the bed of a woman who died in the night. The gendarme wants to see my reaction. I won't give—"

"You have visitors," she said. "It's not normally permitted, but your sister—"

"Rose?"

Léa sprinted toward the gate, her knee aching, but she didn't care. Bursting into the office, breathless, she called out, "Rose."

Her sister rushed forward, arms outstretched, and they embraced. For an instant, everything felt right.

A hand yanked her away. "No touching," a gendarme barked. "You may speak but not touch." He gestured to a table in the corner. "Ten minutes."

At Rose's side stood Maître Mallon. Shame, like a dark cloud, fell over Léa. "Maître Mallon, I'm sorry, I—"

"There's nothing to be sorry about. Rose came to ask for my help. Nothing else needs to be said." He gestured to the table, and they settled around it.

Rose crossed her legs, her gaze on the two officers rifling through her bag. "I brought you a few things," she said, a slight tremble in her voice.